EXPERIENCE DESIGN

The Art of Gathering

How We Meet and Why It Matters

Priya Parker · 2018

A facilitator shows why so many of our gatherings fall flat, and how to design meetings, dinners, celebrations and even funerals that people actually remember.[1,2]

WHY READ IT

- It will change how you host everything, from a meeting to a birthday[2,4]
- Memorable stories from gatherings around the world[2]
- Specific, surprising advice, like never starting with logistics[2,4]

GET THE BOOK



The Art of Gathering by Priya Parker

Riverhead Books (Penguin Random House), 2018. At your local bookshop, your library, or as an audiobook.

The book ↗ Priya Parker ↗

A free guide inspired by *The Art of Gathering* by Priya Parker. Not affiliated with the author or publisher.

Please read the book

THE BIG IDEA

Purpose over category

"Dinner party", "meeting" and "birthday" are formats, not reasons. Parker argues that most gatherings disappoint because we copy the format and skip the purpose. A good purpose is specific, and even disputable: reasonable people could disagree with it.[2,3]

THREE LESSONS

1. **Don't be a chill host**
   Staying hands-off leaves guests unprotected. Use your authority generously: protect guests, connect them, and treat them as equals.[2,4]

2. **Exclusion is design**
   Who you leave out, how many people come and where you meet all shape what can happen.[2]

3. **Endings matter**
   Don't end with logistics or thank-yous. Give a last call, look back at what happened, and help people return to ordinary life.[6]

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THE FRAMEWORK

The arc of a gathering[1,2,4]

The book follows a gathering from first idea to final goodbye. Five of its moves:[2,4]

1 Decide why

A specific, disputable purpose

Is a funeral to mourn a death or celebrate a life? Each leads to a very different gathering.[2,3]

Try: Ask "why?" until someone could disagree.

2 Close doors

Exclude with generosity

The guest list is the first test of your purpose.[2]

Try: Invite only who serves the purpose.

3 Create a temporary world

Pop-up rules

Explicit rules that hold only for this gathering replace unspoken etiquette.[4]

Try: Try no phones, or no job titles.

4 Open with intention

Never start with logistics

Prime guests before they arrive and mark a threshold into the gathering.[2,5]

Try: Send a note that sets the mood.

5 Cause good controversy

Real over polished

Invite honesty and productive disagreement instead of everyone's best behavior.[2,4]

Try: As host, go first in being real.

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FROM THE BOOK

Tools to try

15 Toasts

A dinner format described in the book.[4]

1. Choose a theme connected to the purpose.
2. During dinner, each guest gives a short, honest toast on it.
3. Let the evening build, one toast at a time.

A closing ritual

From the book's chapter on endings.[6]

1. Give a last call so people know the end is near.
2. Look inward: one moment to reflect on what happened.
3. Turn outward: each person names one thing they're taking back with them.

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MAKE IT YOURS

Try it before your next gathering

1. Write its category, then ask “why?” three times.
2. Rewrite the purpose until someone could disagree with it.
3. Write two pop-up rules and a 30-second opening.
4. Design the ending, not just the start.

REFLECT

What was your last gathering really for?

Who did you invite out of habit rather than purpose?

Try it in Sedi: Plan the gathering as a project in Timely's Planning view, with its purpose in the event details.

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🕯️ The Art of Gathering

Priya Parker · Riverhead Books (Penguin Random House) · 2018

The book: penguinrandomhouse.com/books/319055/the-art-of-gathering-by-priya-parker

Priya Parker: priyaparker.com

ISBN: 9781594634925

This guide only scratches the surface. The book has the research, the stories and the nuance behind every idea here. Buy it from an independent bookshop, borrow it from your library, or listen to the audiobook.

A NOTE FROM ME

I'm not affiliated with Priya Parker or the publisher, and this guide isn't sponsored or endorsed by them. I've learned a lot from this book, so I'm sharing what I took from it, for free, in case it helps you too. Everything here is my own summary, in my own words. The good ideas are the author's; any mistakes are mine.

The maker of Sedi

SOURCES

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